

Mira Serhal

PhD Candidate in Economics

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🌐 Personal website

CURRENT POSITION

2025 – **Teaching & Research Fellow** (*Attachée Temporaire d'Enseignement et de Recherche*)
Department of Economics, CY Cergy Paris University, France

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Development Economics, Family Economics, Gender Economics, Climate Change, Applied Microeconomics

EDUCATION

2022 – **PhD in Economics**
CY Cergy Paris University (THEMA) & ESSEC Business School, France
Supervisors: Olivier Donni and Maëlys de la Rupelle

2022 – 2023 **Advanced Master in Business Administration Research**
ESSEC Business School, France

2021 – 2022 **MSc in Economic Analysis**
CY Cergy Paris University, France

2018 – 2020 **MSc in Economics**
American University of Beirut, Lebanon

2015 – 2018 **BSc in Economics**
American University of Beirut, Lebanon

PUBLICATIONS

Law versus Custom: Can Personal Status Reforms Change Marital Practices?

with Maëlys de la Rupelle — *Revue d'économie du développement*, 2026

We examine whether personal status law reforms can change deeply rooted marital customs, exploiting India's 2019 ban on instant triple talaq. Using three waves of National Family Health Survey data in a difference-in-differences framework, we find that the probability of divorce among Muslim women fell slightly after the reform, likely reflecting a shift toward other forms of divorce such as khula, together with a rise in spousal abandonment. Prohibiting a specific practice may thus curb certain harms while generating unintended consequences.

PAPERS

The Effect of Banning Instant Triple Divorce on Domestic Violence: Evidence from the Triple Talaq Law in India

with Maëlys de la Rupelle

We investigate whether divorce laws influence domestic violence and women's bargaining power, exploiting India's ban on the instant triple talaq practised by Muslim men. Using a triple difference-in-differences design comparing ever-married Muslim and non-Muslim women before and after the reform, we find that the law significantly increased physical domestic violence and decision-making authority among Muslim women, consistent with a "male backlash" mechanism. The effect depends on the salience of Muslims' minority status, the political representation of Hindu nationalist parties and local media exposure, and is stronger for younger couples.

Childcare Time in France: The Impact of Parents' Work Time

with Olivier Donni

Using the 2009–2010 French Time Use Survey, in which both parents are observed on a weekday and a weekend day, we develop the first structural framework modelling the allocation of childcare time over the week, distinguishing routine from non-routine activities, with work time instrumented by hourly wages, socio-professional work-time averages and departmental unemployment rates. We find a consistent trade-off between work time and childcare, concentrated in routine care, while non-routine activities are comparatively preserved. Responses are strongly gendered: when mothers work more, fathers increase childcare, whereas when fathers work more, mothers do not, with adjustment occurring through paid care.

The Effect of Floods on Gender-Based Violence in India

I estimate the effect of flood exposure on crimes against women in India by combining satellite-derived flood data with court cases filed in the lower judiciary between 2010 and 2017 across 576 districts. Using the heterogeneity-robust difference-in-differences estimator of de Chaisemartin and D'Haultfœuille (2024), I find that floods significantly increase filed cases of sexual harassment, domestic violence and total crimes against women, and that the share of domestic violence in total cases rises after floods. The findings highlight the gendered consequences of climate-related disasters and the need for gender-sensitive disaster response.

CONFERENCES AND SEMINARS

2026	3rd Development Economics Workshop (Durham, UK)
2025	5th International Conference on Development Economics, ICDE (Paris Nanterre University, France); 41 ^{èmes} Journées de Microéconomie Appliquée, JMA (Poitiers, France); 4th Workshop on Gender and Economics (Luxembourg); EUDN PhD Workshop on Development Economics (Clermont-Ferrand, France); SITES Summer School in Development Economics (Prato, Italy); ESSEC Student Research Seminar (Cergy, France)
2024	AFSE Annual Congress (Bordeaux, France); Workshop “Gender Issues and Development” (Paris Nanterre University, France); THEMA Theoretical and Applied Economics Seminar (Cergy, France); ESSEC Student Research Seminar (Cergy, France)
2023	IOEA Seminar (Cargèse, France); ESSEC Student Research Seminar (Cergy, France)

SUMMER SCHOOLS AND TRAINING WORKSHOPS

May 2026	CodeChella Madrid (3rd edition) — Mixtape Sessions & CUNEF Universidad Madrid, Spain Four-day intensive workshop on modern causal inference—difference-in-differences and panel-data inference—taught by Scott Cunningham, with sessions on writing and publishing a research paper by Dan Rees and Mark Anderson.
June 2025	14th Summer School in Development Economics — SITES (Italian Association of Development Economists) & Monash Centre for Development Economics and Sustainability Prato, Italy Three-day programme combining invited lectures (D. Mookherjee, C. Valente, K. Deininger, O. Bargain, among others) with participant presentations.
May 2023	20th Institutional and Organizational Economics Academy (IOEA) Cargèse, France One-week academy with morning lectures, methodological workshops and seminars in which participants present their papers. Awarded the Accessit for best PhD project.
July 2019	Arab-German Joint Program on Behavioral and Experimental Economics — Institute of Law and Economics, University of Hamburg Hamburg, Germany Three-week hands-on programme on behavioral economics and the design, implementation and analysis of laboratory experiments, concluding with a group research project.

TEACHING

2022 –	CY Cergy Paris University Teaching & Research Fellow (2025–), Teaching Assistant (2022–2025) Advanced Econometrics (3rd-year undergraduate, French) Econometrics (3rd-year undergraduate, French) Introduction to Econometrics (3rd-year engineering, English) Computer Science (3rd-year undergraduate, French) Microeconomics (1st-year undergraduate, French) Descriptive Statistics (1st-year undergraduate, French)
2024	ESSEC Business School Teaching Assistant Microeconomics (Grande École, pre-master, English)
2019 – 2021	American University of Beirut Assistant Instructor and Teaching Assistant Microeconomics (1st-year undergraduate, English) Applied Econometrics (3rd-year undergraduate, English)

AWARDS AND SCHOLARSHIPS

2023	Accessit for best PhD project, IOEA
2022	PhD Scholarship, Labex MME-DII
2021 – 2022	Excellence Scholarship, CY Cergy Paris University
2020	Samir Makdisi Award in Economics, American University of Beirut
2019 – 2020	Graduate Assistantship, American University of Beirut
2018	Dean's Honor List, American University of Beirut

ADMINISTRATIVE POSITIONS

2023 –	PhD student representative, CY Cergy Paris University
2023 –	Doctoral School representative (substitute), CY Cergy Paris University

SKILLS

Languages	Arabic (native), English (fluent), French (fluent)
Software	Stata (proficient), R (intermediate), SAS (intermediate), Python (basics), $\LaTeX$, MS Office

REFERENCES

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